



INTERVIEW

Poet-politician. Charismatic leader. Man of the masses. Sikkim Chief Minister Pawan Chamling is clearly a man on a mission. Well into his 3rd term of governance, he talks about his vision for Sikkim and the challenges that lie ahead.

1. Fourteen years of uninterrupted stint in power. How is the feeling?

Answer: The feeling is one that of solid contentment for being able to carry forward some incremental development initiatives to improve the socio-economic condition of the people of Sikkim. As evident from the existing economic statistics, Sikkim has moved ahead impressively to emerge as one of the most progressive States in the country. But there are many more things still undone. And the fight must go on.

2. How do you like to describe your fourteen years of running the Government in the State?

Answer: Political leaders, philosophers and thinkers down many centuries have variously defined political philosophy lending it with new dimension as we progress into the new age. As per the ideals propounded by the political thinkers, rule of the people and government of the people prevails today in the democratic nations the world over. As one of the practitioners of the democratic philosophy, I have been in the helm of State affairs for the last fourteen years. However, what I have observed very acutely is that however easy it might be to define the theory, it is equally difficult to implement and translate them into reality. I have felt that to make the working of real democracy successful, every citizen will have to be capable and empowered. Until and unless the citizens are capable of taking their own decisions, discriminate between what is harmful and useful for the society, secure their rights and conscious about their duties, Democracy in real terms and meaning can not be successful. The high goal of democratic philosophy, after all, is to ensure freedom, peace and progress of the people and empower them to determine their own destiny. The question is one that of raising the economic standard and individual capacity of the every citizen. The Government's role is one that of facilitator providing its citizens with conducive environment and opportunities to work and live with dignity and respect. To make the democratic system vibrant, the people will have to cash on all opportunities in the interest of the society and the Nation. In the context of the State of Sikkim, I have been trying to address all these aspects

including knowledge, professional expertise and capacity building of our people.

3. What are the issues you think are very important for your State?

Answer: When we took over the rein of government in 1994, the immediate issues were restoration of Democracy, emotional integration, rule of law and to redeem human dignity and propriety. Today, after 14 years we have been able to restore Democracy where people are living with full human dignity and are emotionally entwined with their countrymen across the country. We have made supreme sacrifices to bring about this transformation in the life of the people of Sikkim. At this point of time, there is a gradual shift in our priorities. They are primarily concerned with economic development and human resource development.

4. What are your development priorities?

Answer: We have taken policy decision to base all our development initiatives on the available natural resources. In Sikkim, only 14 percent land is available with people for habitation and farming. Rest of the area comprises of Himalayas, rivers, glaciers, lakes, exquisite range of flora and fauna. The State Government has realized that together with the preservation of our age-old culture, tradition, the socio-political rights and our environment, it is time to change our outlook. We took the people in confidence to adjust to new modes of development interventions and familiarize with new instruments of economic prosperity. Therefore, our development priorities naturally are utilizing our water resources to generate electricity, development and promotion of eco-tourism, development of horticulture and floriculture. In the area of farming practices, we are calling upon people to go back to the roots to take up traditional organic farming system as practiced and stabilized by our forefathers while at the same time inject certain modern technology in keeping with the new age.

5. How do you intend to tackle the menace of poverty and unemployment?

Answer: From day one, we have earmarked seventy percent of our plan budget for rural sector. We have also launched a number of poverty alleviation measures including Rural Housing Scheme, Land Bank Scheme,

Antodaya Annadan Yojana. As far as unemployment is concerned, we do not have any. Because, we have created a host of employment opportunities to our people including in trade, tourism, hospitality services, horticulture, floriculture so on and so forth. The question now is to what degree is our young people able to tap all prospective opportunities. We have realized that there is need to make our people more capable and skillful to tap all emerging opportunities in the State.

Therefore, we have now instituted a separate Directorate of Capacity building to train our youths in different trades and disciplines. We draw list of aspiring candidates to undergo different training programmes based on their aptitude. The idea is to create a pool of human resources so that all opportunities created in the State are adequately harnessed by our people. We have realized that without trained people, our people are not able to avail of the emerging opportunities in very many fields. We undertook similar campaign last year to generate awareness among people. Continuing with the same zeal and enthusiasm, we have also made provision for a 2 percent budget allocation in individual Department to undertake similar training programme.

6. There are lots of upheavals taking place in the political realm both at the regional and national levels. What is your observation?

Answer: We often talk about administrative reforms and economic reforms. But what we are missing altogether is that unless there is political reforms, everything we undertake will fail to meet the desired result. This is because of the fact that in a democratic set up, political system controls every other thing. Therefore, we need a process of political cleansing whereby all our political leaders rise above party affiliation and the specter of casteism. Unless, such reforms come about, people's welfare will not be complete and progress of the Nation will slow down. In a democratic system, politics forms the epicenter where the fate of the people is determined and the future of the nation is regulated. Therefore, we cannot afford to let political practices degenerate. Under all circumstances, people's interest must come above individual or party's interest.